

owed to creditors is paid off.” This tends to happen when people don’t have a clear, valid will or only their own name on their assets and no will.

“The probate process can be long and costly, taking months and sometimes years to resolve. The longer it takes, the more it will cost, leaving potential heirs with less than the deceased may have intended,” [FindLaw.com](#) advises. Without the trust, Eden would have had to hire a probate lawyer (which she couldn’t afford) to help her get access to her father’s assets.

So as a new orphan, Eden had to immediately jump into action to avoid probate and figure out what to do with everything her parents had accrued during their lives. Death certificate in hand, she headed to Bank of America to get access to her father’s bank account. She was surprised to learn it was overdrawn by \$2,000. His brain cancer had caused him to buy all kinds of unnecessary products in bulk from Costco. He’d also stopped paying his bills or paying attention to his bills, some of which were set on automatic payment, so car payments, insurance payments, and mortgage payments were all going through. He’d also stopped paying his credit card bills.

Eden couldn’t afford to deal with all of this. Luckily, her mom’s money had been left in a bank in Israel. She transferred that to her account in LA and used it to pay for her dad’s mistakes and his funeral. Before that, Eden said, she had maybe \$1,000 to her name. For his burial, she chose the “IKEA of funerals,” as she called it— the cheapest options all around—which still ran her \$10,000. (Traditional Judaism doesn’t allow for cremation, the truly cheapest option. [US-funerals.com](#) says a cremation runs \$1,500 to \$3,000 on average. But Eden’s extended family was pressuring her to follow Jewish law.)

Buying a plot in the ground is essentially buying real estate. Eden joked that a great gift you can give your family would be buying a burial plot for yourself in advance. She called the plots “the biggest scam” next to funerals. “I was pretty shocked that they demand so much money. It’s like, ‘They’re dead! They’re not going to even appreciate this!’” she said. I’m inclined to agree. Whenever someone tells me that because of my tattoos I won’t be able to be buried in a Jewish cemetery, I always reply, “I’ll be dead, so who cares?”

When TV writer Steve Basilone’s mom died of cancer, Steve was her only child, so most of the responsibilities fell on his shoulders. He remembered, in